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Raj Verma

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India–China rivalry, border dispute, border standoffs, and crises

Raj Verma 

School of International Relations and Public Affairs, Shanghai International Studies University, Shanghai, China

Why did China intrude along the disputed border with India in May 2020? This question has baffled governments, policy makers, scholars, and analysts across the globe. There is no clarity even in the Indian government regarding China's intrusions at multiple points along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in May 2020. Subrahmanyam Jaishankar, Minister of External Affairs, India, stated that Beijing has provided five different reasons at different points in time for the incursions in May 2020. However, he did not elaborate on the reasons.¹

In June 2020, troops from both sides clashed in the Galwan Valley, leading to casualties on both sides. The last armed clash took place in 1975 when four Indian troops were killed in an ambush by Chinese forces at Tulung La in Arunachal Pradesh. The Galwan Valley clash has upended the bilateral relationship, increased tensions, and frictions, and exacerbated the mistrust between the two “Asian giants.”²

Multiple explanations have been provided by scholars and analysts for China's incursions along the LAC in May 2020. These explanations encompass a broad spectrum including domestic problems in China, to domestic factors in India such as rapid pace of infrastructure buildup in the border areas by India, the abrogation of Article 370 and Amit Shah's (Minister of Home Affairs, India) statement regarding restoration of Aksai Chin and Pakistan administered Kashmir into India, to systemic factors such as change in the balance of power which favors China vis-à-vis India due to rapid increase in China's material capabilities in the new millennium, and India's relations with other countries especially the burgeoning India–US ties.³

This special issue examines the different explanations for Chinese intrusions along the LAC. It provides a holistic explanation for China's actions and also discusses various aspects of India's and China's foreign and security policies, India–China rivalry, domestic aspects of the two countries and their impact on the foreign policy and bilateral ties between the two countries, and the bilateral ties of the two countries with other countries and their impact on

the India–China ties and the border dispute. It seeks to inform policy and build a bridge between policy and practice.

Before I proceed further, a word of caution is required. The article analyzes different plausible explanations for China's incursions in May 2020. The contributors have been unable to establish causation or cause and effect relationship. This is due to the following reasons. First, as mentioned above, Beijing has not provided a proper explanation/reason for its actions. Second, Chinese analysts have also not been able to offer a reasonable explanation.⁴ Third, it has been extremely difficult for the contributors to get primary data especially access to Chinese government sources and information from Chinese analysts and scholars. Vast majority of the Chinese analysts/scholars contacted by the contributors did not respond to their queries for research. Those who did respond also provided no single reason/explanation to the contributors. In their responses, they all blamed New Delhi for the border problem without providing an objective and adequate explanation for their assertion.

Thus, the contributors have employed a “mirroring policy” model/strategy. This strategy has been adopted in Chinese studies because it is difficult to conduct interviews with government officials and members of the armed forces in China. But by studying the views and analyses of Chinese foreign policy experts, one can gain insights into the factors that influence China's foreign policy. The premise of the model/strategy is that the experts' views mirror Beijing's views to a certain degree. This is because the Chinese government can significantly influence the range of publishable views and research priorities of scholars/experts in China. Thus, when certain views on China's foreign policy or China's relations with other states appear in the debate, it implies they are acceptable to the Chinese government.⁵

India–China rivalry

India and China suffer from a positional, spatial, enduring, protracted, and strategic rivalry.⁶ Positional rivalry is defined as competition between two or more states “over which state will benefit from possessing greater influence in a given global or regional locale.”⁷ Positional rivalry between the two “Asian giants” is due to the competing visions of their country's place in the international system and the pursuit of great power status in the Asia-Pacific and beyond. This quest is based on their historical national greatness: long and respected civilizational histories which they treasure and are proud of, and extensive empires that extended way beyond the present political boundaries. Both countries also have different views of history and the belief and determination that their country will play a major role in world affairs. This has provided the edifice for the rivalry.⁸

The positional rivalry first emerged between colonial India and Republic of China (ROC) under Chiang Kai-shek, and later between the dominion of India (formed on August 15, 1947) and Republic of India (formed on January 26, 1950), and the ROC and the People's Republic of China (PRC, formed on October 1, 1949). Elements of the positional rivalry were visible even before India became independent during the Asian Relations Conference held in New Delhi during April–March 1947.⁹

India and China suffer from a spatial rivalry. Spatial rivalries between countries pertain to (disputed) territory, population, resources, location and may even be of symbolic significance. It emerges when two or more countries aspire to control some territory and continues as long as one country has an expectation – reasonable or unreasonable – to gain and maintain exclusive control over this territory.¹⁰ India–China spatial rivalry is due to the dispute over Ladakh and Aksai Chin (including the Shaksgam Valley ceded by Pakistan to China in 1963) in the western sector, in the central sector across the states of Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh (where the differences are minor and considered manageable) and over Arunachal Pradesh in the eastern sector along the disputed border. The territorial dispute is the legacy of British colonialism. Ganguly et al. argue that while the spatial India–China is important, the positional rivalry between the two countries is more significant in their overall rivalry.¹¹

Additionally, India and China suffer from an enduring rivalry because of persistent militarized conflicts between them¹² starting in 1959 and continuing in the twenty-first century including border clashes and standoffs in 1986, 2013, 2014, 2017, and other incidents, ambushes/skirmishes such as the killing of four Indian troops by Chinese forces in 1975 in Arunachal Pradesh, localized conflicts such as in Nathu La in 1967 and a border war in 1962. The rivalry is protracted because it has continued into the twenty-first century and there are little or no signs of abating in the near future. The rivalry is also strategic because elites in both countries have attributed an image of an “enemy” to the other country. While ROC and PRC leadership and elites considered India as imperial power and a rival after India became independent, India perceived China as a rival and an “expansionist” and “hegemonic” power after China’s annexation of Tibet in 1950–1951.¹³

The India–China rivalry is also complex due to the involvement of regional and global powers such as the US, erstwhile Soviet Union, Russia, Pakistan, Japan, and other countries both in the twentieth century and in the new millennium. In the twenty-first century, to counter-balance a rising, aggressive, and assertive China, India has increasingly aligned itself with the US as Beijing tries to surpass Washington to become the pre-dominant global power. New Delhi has strengthened diplomatic, defense, and strategic ties with Japan, Vietnam, Australia, and other countries in East Asia, which are also wary of a rising China. Due to India’s increasing involvement in the Indo-Pacific,

which is the epicenter of US–China rivalry/competition, New Delhi’s place in Beijing’s strategic calculus has evolved. Beijing’s perception of New Delhi is increasingly being influenced by how the latter responds to Washington’s Indo-Pacific strategy. Subsequently, China has further strengthened its strategic partnership with Pakistan. As China gets closer to Pakistan, India becomes closer to the US and Japan, enveloping the two countries in a vicious circle leading to increasing mistrust between India and China and deterioration in the bilateral relationship, with the two countries in state of persistent security dilemma which heightens the probability of escalation and conflict/war.¹⁴

Intersection of India–China positional and spatial rivalry

Scholars have argued that there is an intersection of positional and spatial dimensions in the India-China rivalry. Ganguly et al. contend that Tibet is not the epicenter of the India-China rivalry but it is deeply linked to the spatial and positional rivalries between the two “Asian giants” because the territories disputed between the two countries have historical links with Tibet.¹⁵ India–China positional rivalry in Burma (now Myanmar) and the Himalayan states of Nepal, Sikkim, and Bhutan are/were linked to Tibet. Additionally, the 1962 India–China border war progressed as wars between positional rivals have proceeded in history with “multilateralization of the war” with India seeking aid from the US, the UK, and other Western powers. India’s defeat in the war had positional consequences as India was no longer considered a candidate for leadership in Asia. While China continued to play an important role in the wider strategic system in Asia, India, was confined to a position of a marginal player in Asia in the twentieth century and became more focused on South Asian affairs. India–China spatial rivalry continued after the 1962 war because the war did not resolve the border dispute.¹⁶

Francine Frankel argues that the border dispute also raised the question of being the dominant power in Asia with both countries not willing to accept each other’s claim as acceptance would be perceived as deference to the other.¹⁷ In 1962, India’s Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru stated,

It is a little naïve to think that the trouble with China was essentially due to a dispute over some territories. It had deeper reasons. Two of the largest countries in Asia confronted each other over a vast border. They differed in many ways. And the test was whether any one of them would have a more dominating position than the other on the border and in Asia itself.¹⁸

India–China border standoffs, clashes, conflicts, and war

The Sino-Indian positional and spatial rivalry has led to numerous standoffs, clashes/ambushes/skirmishes, and conflicts along the disputed border in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries. It also led to the 1962 border war in

which India was defeated. This section discusses some of the major clashes/ conflicts/crises which have occurred along the disputed border culminating in the May 2020 incursions.

In the late 1950s, there were multiple standoffs and skirmishes between Indian and Chinese troops along the disputed border. The first skirmish occurred in August 1959 at Longju, a few months after the Dalai Lama escaped from Tibet. Chinese forces initiated hostilities at Khinzemane and attacked the Indian post at Longju. After the attack, India did not return to Longju post, and the area has been occupied by China. The next skirmish was at Kongka Pass in Ladakh in October 1959 when ten members of an Indian paramilitary force were killed in an attack by Chinese forces. Seven soldiers were captured and the remaining escaped. The incident led to an uproar in India and heightened tensions between the two countries. Nehru realized the gravity of the border dispute and the two sides tried to resolve the border issue through diplomatic means. Border negotiations failed, and Nehru adopted the “Forward Policy” in November 1961¹⁹ which has been provided as the justification for the 1962 India–China war by some scholars.

In 1962, China launched simultaneous attacks in the western and eastern sectors with underequipped Indian military crumbling under the Chinese offensive. The war altered the distribution of territory along the disputed border in China’s favor. While China restored status quo ante bellum and established the McMahon Line as the frontier in the eastern sector, its victory allowed it to capture and administer the Aksai Chin region in the western sector. The 1962 war sowed the seeds for antagonistic relations between the two countries and left deep scars in the minds of the Indian elite.²⁰

The next major conflict occurred in September 1967 at Nathu La and Cho La in Sikkim (which was deemed to be an Indian protectorate). A fence laying operation by Indian forces prompted an attack by the Chinese forces resulting in Indian casualties. Indian soldiers were better armed and equipped relative to 1962 and employed heavy artillery fire, and destroyed a large number of Chinese bunkers causing a large number of Chinese casualties. After a brief lull in fighting, Chinese forces tried to over run an Indian position at Cho La at the Sikkim-Tibet border. India had reinforced its troops in the region who repulsed the Chinese assault.²¹

In 1986, a major crisis occurred at Sumdorong Chu in Tawang district in erstwhile North-East Frontier Agency (NEFA, presently Arunachal Pradesh). Chief of Army Staff, General Krishnaswami Sundarji launched “Operation Falcon” and airlifted a brigade to Zemithang, south of the McMahon Line and Indian troops occupied the heights in the Sumdorong Chu Valley after China occupied a seasonal observer post near Thag La ridge. From October 1986 to March 1987, India conducted operation “Exercise Chequerboard” to simulate India’s combat capabilities vis-à-vis China in the eastern sector. Tensions were exacerbated in February 1987 when India decided to change the status of

NEFA to a full-fledged state of Arunachal Pradesh. The crisis brought the two countries to the brink of war. Diplomacy averted war with Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi visiting China in December 1988. The crisis was finally over in 1993, and border agreements were signed between the two countries in 1993 and 1996.²²

In the new millennium, the two countries signed border agreements in 2005, 2012, 2013, and 2017 to maintain peace and tranquility in the border areas. Despite the border agreements, border standoffs, and clashes between Indian and Chinese security forces have increased significantly especially since 2013. This can be attributed to multiple factors. Increase in economic growth in India has provided the resources to enhance infrastructure and improve connectivity on its side of the LAC (although India still considerably lags behind China regarding border infrastructure). This has allowed Indian troops to patrol in areas where they did not patrol before. The frequency of Indian and Chinese patrols has also increased due to better infrastructure. Both sides have also set up optronic equipment and surveillance devices to keep tabs on each other in certain parts of the disputed border. This has increased the incidence of Indian and Chinese troops facing off against each other. With increase in China's material capabilities and President Xi Jinping coming to power in 2012, China has become more assertive regarding its territorial claims, and there is more aggressive patrolling by Chinese troops along the border. The nationalist Modi government in India has also espoused a policy of zero compromise on territorial sovereignty, and Indian security forces have also been patrolling more vigorously. There have also been reports of Chinese troops dismantling and/or destroying temporary embankments, construction materials, surveillance equipment, and rations on the Indian side of the LAC. Reports also indicate that China has continued to nibble Indian territory in the new millennium especially in Ladakh in the western sector.²³

Three major standoffs between Indian and Chinese troops occurred in 2013, 2014, and 2015. In April 2013, Chinese troops intruded 19 km into Indian territory in the Depsang Valley, 30 km south of Daulat Beg Oldi (DBO) in the disputed Aksai Chin region. The incident occurred 1 month before Premier Li Keqiang's visit to India. Indian forces built an encampment 300 m away from where the Chinese were camped. After 3 weeks of negotiations, both sides withdrew on May 5 with India agreeing not to build bunkers/sheds (this was an Indian riposte to the Chinese tent in Depsang) in the Chumar sector. In September 2014, during President Xi's visit to India, Chinese troops intruded in the Demchok and Chumar sectors in Aksai Chin. This was in response to India's construction of an old observation hut in Demchok in August 2014 which was dismantled as part of the 2013 agreement. Modi directly told Xi that border incursions and transgressions will adversely affect bilateral ties. New Delhi also contemplated special forces operation to evict Chinese troops who had intruded into the Indian perceived LAC. The

crisis was resolved a week after Xi returned to China with both sides agreeing not to build any infrastructure in the area. However, Xi and China paid no heed to Modi's repeated calls to delineate and demarcate the LAC.²⁴

Another small but significant altercation occurred in Burtse, east of DBO, in September 2015 in the Depsang plains. The crisis emerged after Indian security forces demolished a hut with cameras and solar panels (used for surveillance) built by China in territory claimed by India. As tensions mounted, both sides called for reinforcements. The standoff was resolved by local military commanders on the ground without intervention by the governments of the two countries, which highlighted improvement in the bilateral relations. As a confidence-building measure, the two sides conducted a 12-day joint military exercise in China after the incident was resolved. China has been trying to change the status quo in the Burtse area to ensure that India is unable to overlook the Karakoram Highway, which links Pakistan-occupied-Kashmir with China, and to monitor the activities of Indian troops based in DBO airbase.²⁵

In June 2017, Indian and Chinese troops again clashed at Doklam, Sikkim, at the India–China–Bhutan tri-junction where Indian troops stopped Chinese troops from constructing a road in the territory disputed by Bhutan and China. India's security concerns regarding the "Chicken's neck," a narrow stretch of land that connects mainland India with its north-eastern states, prompted India to stop Chinese road-building activity. The standoff lasted for 73 days. During the standoff, troops from the two countries were involved in a brawl in Pangong Tso Lake with injuries on both sides. According to some analysts, India and China were at the brink of war.²⁶

In May 2020, China violated the border agreements signed between the two countries with Chinese forces intruding at multiple points along the LAC and occupying a number of disputed positions – such as the northern bank of the Pangong Tso Lake, Galwan River Valley, Gogra – Hot Springs area in the Kugrang river valley, the Charding Nala area of Demchok and Y junction or bottleneck in Depsang Plains. They blocked/prevented Indian troops from accessing patrolling points on the Indian side of the LAC. India countered Chinese incursions in May 2020 which led to standoffs, fisticuffs, and brawls between Indian and Chinese troops in different areas along the LAC. On 15/ June 16, 2020, troops from the two sides clashed in the Galwan Valley leading to casualties on both sides. Both sides have blamed each other for the clash.

Core arguments and organization of the special issue

The special issue comprises ten articles including the Introduction. The next seven articles analyze different plausible explanations for China's incursions along the LAC in May 2020. Contributors examine factors such as China's domestic politics, China's foreign and security policies and strategies, China's

strategic culture, domestic factors and politics in India, India's infrastructure development along the LAC, China's rising material capabilities and the shift in the overall balance of power between India and China, India's foreign policy especially India-US relations, Sino-Indian relations, and Sino-Indian rivalry in the Indo-Pacific.

In the first article, Prashant Kumar Singh debunks the belief/perception that "China's 'Strategy' of Five Fingers of Tibet" is the rationale for China's incursions in 2020 along the LAC. Some in the strategic community in India believe that President Xi Jinping is following the same revanchist policy propagated by Chairman Mao Zedong to attach Nepal, Sikkim, Bhutan, Arunachal Pradesh, and Ladakh to China based on Tibet's historical claim to these territories under the aegis of China's historical tributary system. By examining the relevant historical literature and conducting interviews with experts on China's foreign policy, the PLA, Tibet-China relations, and India-China relations, Singh highlights that the strategy of five fingers of Tibet is a "faulty prism." Mao never postulated such a strategy and it was never practiced by China in its territorial claims/disputes with countries in South Asia. Employing this flawed lens does not augur well not only for Sino-Indian relations but also India's relations with Nepal and Bhutan, because it leads to alarmist analyses. This is untenable for it will adversely affect public opinion and India's foreign policy choices.

In the next article, Rishika Chauhan argues that China's 2020 incursions along the LAC are explained by China's "salami slicing tactic" to grab territory controlled by India. Through this tactic, China makes small encroachments on the territory of another country and presents them with a *fait accompli* that is to either accept China's land grab or go to war. These land grabs work slowly and effectively to alter the status quo and pose a major strategic challenge for the other country in the medium to long term. It allows China to undertake expansionism without recourse to war. Beijing has been employing this tactic for almost seven decades against India. It has also used this tactic against other countries with which it has sovereignty and territorial disputes including in the South China Sea. This tactic allows Beijing to achieve multiple goals including its core interests such as regime legitimacy and survival, economic growth and development, territorial integrity, aggrandize power and pursue regional hegemony. The salami slicing tactic led to incursions at multiple points along the LAC because Beijing knew from previous experience – in 2013, 2014, 2015, and 2017—that India will provide a robust response to its incursions.

In the following article, Avinash Godbole argues that COVID-19 induced China to intrude along the LAC in 2020. He highlights that although China is powerful, its insecurity about its status makes it risk prone because it has a pessimistic security outlook. Beijing was under severe pressure due to international criticism for its mishandling of the COVID-19 outbreak.

Beijing perceived the virulent criticism and vitriolic international environment as an attempt to contain China's global rise. It also dented China's status as a great power. The legitimacy of the Communist Party of China is linked to China's status, and a benign international environment for China's rise. In the past, Beijing has undertaken coercive military action when it perceived itself to be vulnerable and its strategic advantage was being mitigated or lost. Thus, China intruded along the LAC to showcase strength. It wanted to ensure that New Delhi did not perceive China as weak and not gain leverage over Beijing in the India–China bilateral relationship. It also wanted to send a message to other countries in the Indo-Pacific that COVID-19 will not prevent China from protecting its rise and status and overcoming challenges to its national security, sovereignty, and territorial integrity.

Raj Verma argues that two factors in conjunction explain China's decision to intrude along the LAC in May 2020. First, the construction of border infrastructure especially the Darbuk-Shyok (DS)-DBO road which mitigates China's military/tactical advantage along the LAC. Second, India's Minister of Home Affairs Amit Shah's statement regarding restoration of Aksai Chin and Pakistan occupied Kashmir (PoK) into India after the abrogation of Article 370 in August 2019. Individually, these factors cannot explain Beijing's decision to intrude because the road has been under construction for more than a decade and India's claims to Aksai Chin have not changed in the new millennium. Verma argues that Beijing considers that the border infrastructure buildup by India especially the DS-DBO road would allow India to threaten Aksai Chin according to Shah's statement. This is predicated on Beijing's belief that India has become more risk prone, assertive, and aggressive in its territorial dispute with China under the Hindu nationalist Modi governments. Thus, anxieties and insecurities pertaining to Aksai Chin forced Chinese incursions in May 2020.

Mahesh Shankar in his article draws on the rationalist theory to argue that China's intrusions can be explained by the asymmetric material capabilities between China and India. Rationalist theories employ the difference in material power, both economic and military, between countries as the explanatory variable for state action especially in the context of war and peace. As a country's material capabilities rise especially relative to its adversaries, its strategic calculus will change in the context of its most significant rivals. In the new millennium, China's economy is circa five times India's economy, and its defense expenditure is almost four times India's military expenditure. China's meteoric rise in the twenty-first century especially relative to India has provided Beijing with more military options and opportunities along the disputed border. It has also led to a reduction in the intensity of internal and external threats faced by Beijing, which may have led to a conciliatory posture by Beijing in the past. The huge gulf in material capabilities between the two countries has led to a shift in the balance of power which has allowed Beijing to

adopt a more belligerent posture in the territorial dispute with India. Beijing assumed that New Delhi will succumb to its aggression due to the gap in material capabilities between the two countries.

Dalbair Ahlawat argues that China intruded along the LAC in May 2020 to teach India a lesson reminiscent of the 1962 war. India and China suffer from a positional and spatial rivalry in which the former supersedes the latter. As part of their positional rivalry, China attacked India in 1962 to reduce India's influence in Asia and beyond, highlight India's inability to lead Asia, enhance China's international stature and portray China as the rightful leader of Asia. Beijing aspires to be the preeminent power in Asia and the most powerful country in the world by 2049. India's status has increased significantly in the second decade of the new millennium due to high economic rates of growth and its strategic partnerships with the US, Japan, Australia, and other countries in the Indo-Pacific. Like in 1962, in 2020, China intruded along the border as part of its positional rivalry with India. It wanted to reduce India's increasing clout in the region and force New Delhi to accept China as the preeminent power in the Indo-Pacific by checkmating their positional rivalry in the spatial domain.

In their contribution, Harsh Pant and Vivek Mishra argue that India-US burgeoning ties in the new millennium especially after the Doklam standoff in 2017 both at the bilateral level and in multilateral settings may have provoked Beijing to intrude along the border in 2020. China's rise, its quest to become the preeminent power in Asia and globally, and Beijing's assertive and belligerent behavior in the Indo-Pacific especially along the disputed Sino-Indian border has provided the necessary glue for India and the US to strengthen their bilateral relationship. The expansion of India-US political, diplomatic, economic, defense, and strategic ties significantly affected the balance of power and security and stability in the Indo-Pacific. Beijing perceives strengthening India-US ties as an attempt to contain China's rise in the Indo-Pacific and beyond. China intruded along the LAC to send a message to India not to strengthen its bilateral ties with the US and highlight the limits of Washington's support for India in a conflict.

The last two articles are prescriptive and prognostic in the context of India-China relations. The first article informs Indian policy makers by providing solutions to enhance India's deterrence against China and prevent further land grab. The final article serves as the epilogue and examines the possibility of a conflict or a wider border war between the two "Asian giants."

The article by Sidharth Raimedhi focuses on how can India deter China. It highlights that in the new millennium, India's deterrence vis-a-vis China has been eroding and is currently sub-optimal due to the asymmetry in material capabilities between the two countries. This is after India changed its deterrence against China from "deterrence by denial" to "deterrence by punishment." The article advocates adoption of

a generalized deterrence approach with a greater emphasis on denial. Deterrence by punishment is untenable post the Galwan Valley clash because of extensive military buildup by China including a large presence of Chinese troops close to the LAC. Moreover, India's previous deterrence by denial strategy is outmoded. Raimedhi asserts that India can effectively deter China by significantly increasing military expenditure/power, establishing a resilient domestic defense industrial base, reducing the focus on land warfare, and expanding the role of airpower instead of sea power to inject greater unpredictability. This needs to be buttressed by political and diplomatic measures including flexibility in India's policy of strategic autonomy.

The epilogue to the special issue examines the possibility of war between the two nuclear armed "Asian giants." It highlights that the security situation along the LAC has deteriorated post-Galwan and is likely to further deteriorate in the future. This has ominous implications for regional and global security. Post-Galwan, the likelihood of both vertical and horizontal escalation between the two sides has increased tremendously, both along the disputed border and in the maritime domain (in the Indian Ocean), where India has a military advantage over China. Modi's and Xi's unwillingness to seriously discuss the border issue at the leaders' level has compounded the security situation after the failure of several rounds of talks at the diplomatic and military level to resolve the border crisis. New Delhi's refusal to publicly accept that China now forcibly occupies parts of territory administered by India has further complicated matters. This provides an incentive for Beijing to continue its attempts at land grab because these will be publicly denied by the Modi government. Third, the security dilemma has been exacerbated with both countries amassing troops and sophisticated advanced military platforms with both believing that holding and gaining territory is more significant than political dialogue. Finally, both sides have deployed new technologies and are employing brinkmanship strategies which have elevated the dangers of further attempts at intruding or miscomprehensions which may lead to a conflict or broader war.

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No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

ORCID

Raj Verma  <http://orcid.org/0000-0001-9869-8782>